

ADEK Program Authorization Briefing

Bachelor of Science in Clinical Nutrition & Dietetics (BSCND)

Sports Medicine Minor (SPMD 301–304) & Sports & Fitness Coaching

Concentration (SPMD 305–308)

Khalifa University of Science and Technology | College of Medicine and Health Sciences

Prepared for ADEK Reviewers | Version 5 Enhanced | May 2026

Important Notice — Inferred Content: The Sports & Fitness Coaching Concentration (SPMD 305–308) course syllabi have not yet been formally authored. Course titles, structures, CLOs, and ICREPs alignments presented in this document were inferred by the pipeline team from Dr. Habiba Alsafar's May 2026 email correspondence, the proposed SPMD course table (Kartik Rangaraj/Sara Almessabi), and published ICREPs Level 3 PT competency frameworks. Faculty review and formal UGCC syllabus authoring are mandatory before UGCC submission or ADEK filing.

1. Program Overview

Khalifa University (KU) — ranked 177th globally in QS World University Rankings 2026 and 37th in Times Higher Education Asia University Rankings 2025 — seeks authorization for a comprehensive enhancement to its proposed **Bachelor of Science in Clinical Nutrition and Dietetics (BSCND)**. The BSCND program (QFEmirates Level 6, 124 baseline credits) has received UGCC approval for its 200–400 level core syllabi and aligns with the UAE National Strategy for Wellbeing 2031 and Abu Dhabi's Vision 2030 priority for preventive health and active lifestyles.

This briefing concerns two complementary academic tracks proposed for formal authorization alongside the BSCND core program:

- **Sports Medicine Minor** (SPMD 301–304, 12 credits): Four existing courses pending UGCC review, providing athlete-centred sports science foundations to BSCND graduates.
- **Sports & Fitness Coaching Concentration** (SPMD 305–308, 12 credits): Four newly proposed courses designed to close identified gaps in REPs UAE /

ICREPs Level 3 Personal Trainer competencies, enabling BSCND graduates to pursue UAE fitness-coach registration.

Together, the dual-track offering would bring total program credits from 124 to 136, positioning KU as the first UAE university to offer a degree-integrated pathway to simultaneous Department of Health (DoH) Dietitian eligibility and REPs UAE Personal Trainer registration.

2. Two-Track Program Structure

Track A — Sports Medicine Minor (SPMD 301-304)

Status: Pending UGCC Review | **Credits:** 12 | **Placement:** Y3 Fall through Y4 Fall

Four didactic courses providing comprehensive sports science foundations: anatomy, biomechanics, exercise physiology, injury prevention & rehabilitation, and performance assessment technology. These courses are athlete-centred and do NOT independently confer fitness-coach registration eligibility. They serve as the scientific bedrock upon which the Concentration is built, and as a standalone minor for BSCND students pursuing clinical or research careers in sports nutrition.

Code	Title	Credits	Semester	Format
SPMD 301	Foundations of Sports Medicine	3	Y3 Fall	3L
SPMD 302	Exercise Physiology	3	Y3 Spring	3L
SPMD 303	Injury Prevention & Rehabilitation	3	Y3 Spring	3L
SPMD 304	Performance Assessment & Technology	3	Y4 Fall	2L+1Lab

Track B — Sports & Fitness Coaching Concentration (SPMD 305-308)

Status: Proposed (Habiba Enquiry, May 2026) | **Credits:** 12 |

Placement: Y3 Fall through Y4 Spring

Four applied courses translating the Minor's scientific foundations into professional fitness-coaching competencies fully aligned with ICREPs Level 3 Personal Trainer and REPs UAE Group Fitness Instructor registration requirements. SPMD 308 delivers the capstone practicum (200 supervised hours) and embedded CPR/AED/First Aid certification, completing the REPs UAE registration portfolio.

Code	Title	Credits	Semester	Format	ICREPs Alignment
SPMD 305	Personal Training & Exercise Programme Design	3	Y3 Fall	2L+1Lab	Level 3 PT — Programme Design
SPMD 306	Group Fitness, Stretching & Conditioning Instruction	3	Y3 Spring	1L+2Lab	REPs UAE GFI + ICREPs L2/3 GFI
SPMD 307	Fitness Coaching, Behaviour Change & Business of Fitness	3	Y4 Fall	3L	Level 3 PT — Behaviour Change + Professional Practice
SPMD 308	Fitness Coaching Practicum & REPs UAE Certification Capstone	3	Y4 Spring	1L+200 hrs	Level 3 PT — Practical Coaching Hours + First Aid

3. Market Need and Strategic Rationale

The strategic case for this dual-track offering rests on three converging drivers:

3.1 Unmet Regulatory Gap

As confirmed by Dr. Sara Saleh Ahmed Almessabi (Health Educator, Falcon & Balsam, KU CMHS) in her May 2026 response to Dean Dr. Habiba Alsafar: "There is currently no dedicated practical coaching, exercise prescription, or fitness-training component specifically tailored toward fitness coach or personal trainer certification pathways within the Sports Medicine Minor itself." The proposed Concentration directly addresses this documented gap. A gap analysis against 12 REPs UAE registration requirements confirmed that only Sports Nutrition (NUTR 305) was fully covered by the current curriculum.

3.2 UAE Fitness Industry Regulatory Landscape

The UAE fitness sector is governed by a layered regulatory framework requiring professional registration before employment in any licensed gym or health club:

- **REPs UAE** (Register of Exercise Professionals UAE): National mandatory registration body operating under ICREPs global standards. Requires ICREPs-accredited Level 3 PT qualification + First Aid + documented practical hours. Annual fee: AED 450 + VAT.
- **Abu Dhabi Sports Council (ADSC)**: Emirate-level enforcer — all Abu Dhabi health clubs must employ only REPs UAE-registered fitness professionals. Directly applicable to KU graduates.
- **Dubai Sports Council (DSC)**: Originator of REPs UAE; equivalent mandatory registration circular for all Dubai health clubs.
- **General Authority of Sports (GAS)**: Federal regulator under Federal Decree-Law No. 4/2023 — identifies sports and fitness as a national priority sector.
- **Department of Health Abu Dhabi (DoH)**: Issues Dietitian licence (Bachelor + 2 yrs experience + exam). Separate credential from fitness-coach registration; SPMD 307 CLO5 explicitly defines referral boundaries between Dietitian and fitness-coach scopes.

3.3 Dual-Credential Value Proposition

BSCND graduates completing the Concentration would hold a unique dual-credential profile: DoH-eligible Registered Dietitian plus REPs UAE-registered Personal Trainer. No UAE university currently offers this combination at undergraduate degree level. This aligns with Abu Dhabi's Vision 2030

preventive health priorities and creates high-value employment pathways in clinical nutrition, sports performance, and integrative wellness coaching at premium UAE health clubs, hospital wellness centres, and national sports programmes.

4. Regulator Alignment Summary

Regulator	Level	SPMD Course(s)	Alignment
REPs UAE	National	305, 306, 307, 308	ICREPs Level 3 PT competency units fully mapped across all 4 courses
ADSC	Abu Dhabi Emirate	307, 308	Regulatory compliance module (CLO2) + practicum in ADSC-overseen facilities
DSC	Dubai Emirate	307, 308	Cross-emirate regulatory awareness; REPs UAE ID compliant with DSC requirements
GAS	Federal	305, 307	Federal Decree-Law No. 4/2023 framing; national sports priority sector rationale
DoH	Abu Dhabi Health	307, 308	Dietitian vs. fitness-coach scope differentiation; dual-credential capstone narrative
MoHRE	Federal/ Commercial	307, 308	Work permit, DED trade licence, freelance model, Emiratisation targets

5. Five-Quarter Implementation Roadmap (Q3 2026 - Q3 2027)

Quarter	Phase	Minor (301-304)	Concentration (305-308)	Decision Gate
Q3 2026 Jul-Sep 2026	Authoring & UGCC Submission	Finalise UGCC packet: 4 syllabi + PLO-CLO matrix +	Author SPMD 305-308 syllabi using KU template;	UGCC bundled review (SPMD 301-308 in single cycle)

		degree plan update	benchmark against ICREPs Level 3 PT	
Q4 2026 Oct-Dec 2026	ADEK Draft & Concentration UGCC	Respond to UGCC feedback; prepare ADEK Program Authorization draft package	Submit SPMD 305–308 to UGCC following CMHS College Council endorsement	ADEK Program Authorization (minor); UGCC approval (concentration)
Q1 2027 Jan-Mar 2027	MoHESR/MoE Filing & ADEK Concentration Submission	File SPMD Minor with MoHESR / Ministry of Education	Submit Sports & Fitness Coaching Concentration to ADEK for authorization	MoE / MoHESR approval (minor); ADEK intake of concentration file
Q2 2027 Apr-Jun 2027	Marketing & KU Senate/ Board Sign-off	Launch marketing; update undergraduate catalog 2027–28; advising materials	KU Senate and Board of Trustees sign-off on Concentration	KU Board of Trustees approval; marketing go-live
Q3 2027 Jul-Sep 2027	Fall 2027 Launch	SPMD 301 first class — September 2027	SPMD 305 + 306 first classes — September 2027	Go-live + REPs UAE/ADSC alignment letter issued

6. Risk Register

Risk	Probability	Impact	Mitigation
SPMD 305–308 syllabi not completed by Q3 2026 UGCC deadline	HIGH	HIGH	Assign dedicated faculty lead (Dr. Carlo Raj + SPMD coordinators) by June 2026; use KU Course Syllabus Template (Dec 2025) as scaffolding; engage ICREPs competency framework directly

UGCC requests credit expansion (~18 credits per Kinda Khalaf note) rather than 12-credit Concentration	MEDIUM	MEDIUM	Prepare alternative 18-credit track design; brief CMHS Dean on trade-offs; confirm with Dr. Carlo Raj before UGCC submission
ICREPs / REPs UAE do not formally accredit SPMD 305-308 as equivalent Level 3 PT qualification	MEDIUM	HIGH	Initiate REPs UAE liaison correspondence Q4 2026; obtain alignment letter commitment by Q3 2027 launch gate
Practicum placement sites (Fitness First, Gold's Gym, NAS Sports Complex) decline MoU agreements	LOW	HIGH	Assign SPMD 308 practicum placement officer (Q3 2026); open formal dialogue Q3 2026; require MoUs in place before ADEK Concentration submission (Q1 2027)
ADEK reviewer challenges QFEmirates Level 6 alignment of applied fitness-coaching competencies	LOW	MEDIUM	Embed explicit QFEmirates Level 6 descriptors in all CLOs; note CLO1 language ("at QFEmirates Level 6") in each concentration syllabus
Kinda Khalaf's note that 18 credits may be needed creates scope conflict with current 12-credit proposal	MEDIUM	MEDIUM	Flag for Dr. Carlo Raj decision before Q3 2026 UGCC submission; downstream agents should not resolve this unilaterally

7. The Ask

ADEK Authorization Request — Three Actions

- **Action 1 — Acknowledge the BSCND Sports Medicine Minor (SPMD 301-304)** as a 12-credit academic minor pending UGCC review, to be included in the ADEK Program Authorization package for the BSCND program (Q4 2026 submission cycle).

- **Action 2 — Acknowledge the Sports & Fitness Coaching Concentration (SPMD 305-308)** as a proposed 12-credit concentration (total program credits: 124 → 136) for ADEK authorization filing in Q1 2027, following UGCC approval of syllabi and CMHS College Council endorsement.
- **Action 3 — Note the dual-credential pathway** (DoH-eligible Dietitian + REPs UAE Personal Trainer) as a strategically differentiated program feature supporting Abu Dhabi's preventive health and sports economy priorities, and engage with REPs UAE / ADSC on an alignment letter confirming ICREPs Level 3 PT equivalency of SPMD 305-308 (target: Q3 2027).

8. Programme Learning Outcomes — Alignment with SPMD Tracks

The five BSCND Programme Learning Outcomes (PLOs) are mapped across the eight SPMD courses to demonstrate coherent QFEmirates Level 6 alignment:

PLO	Label	QFEmirates Domain	SPMD Courses Addressing PLO
PLO1	Problem-Solving with Science	Knowledge	SPMD 301, 302, 303, 304, 305, 307
PLO2	System / Program Design	Skills — Problem Solving	SPMD 301, 302, 303, 304, 305, 306, 308
PLO3	Experimentation & Data Analysis	Skills — Problem Solving	SPMD 302, 304, 305
PLO4	Communication & Collaborative Practice	Skills — Communication + Competence	SPMD 301, 303, 306, 307, 308
PLO5	Ethics & Professional Responsibility	Competence — Responsibility	SPMD 306, 307, 308

PLO5 is particularly significant for the Concentration: SPMD 306 introduces REPs UAE Group Fitness Instructor professional conduct standards; SPMD 307 delivers a dedicated module on UAE regulatory compliance, scope-of-practice ethics, and the legal obligations of fitness professionals operating under MoHRE

work permits and DED trade licences; and SPMD 308 applies ethical practice in 200 hours of supervised professional placement. This PLO5 coverage is explicitly requested by ADEK Program Authorization criteria, which require evidence of professional ethics integration at QFEmirates Level 6.

9. Institutional Stakeholders and Governance

The following stakeholders have been identified in the development of the SPMD programme tracks:

Stakeholder	Role	Contribution to SPMD Development
Dr. Habiba Alsafar	Dean, CMHS	Initiated the fitness-coach credentialing enquiry (May 14, 2026); expressed satisfaction with the proposed pathway; confirmed institutional support for the Concentration direction
Kinda Khalaf	Associate Dean, Undergraduate Studies	Confirmed SPMD courses are preliminary proposals; recommended bundled UGCC submission; noted potential 18-credit strengthened minor option
Dr. Carlo Raj	BSCND Program Director	Drafted initial course proposals (SPMD 305–308) in response to Dean's enquiry; responsible for UGCC submission and programme authoring
Kartik Rangaraj	Period Director, Medical Education 1 & 2	Presented proposed SPMD 305–308 course table to Dean Habiba; confirmed courses are new proposals under Kinda Khalaf's guidance
Sara Saleh Ahmed Almessabi	Health Educator, Falcon & Balsam	Provided detailed written response to Dean confirming no current practical coaching pathway; identified externally available certifications (NASM, ACE, ISSA, REPs UAE); created shared BSCND Teams folder as document repository
Julie Angela Brazzatti	BSCND Program Coordinator	Programme coordination and administrative support for UGCC submission process

10. Supporting Evidence — Institutional and Policy Context

The following institutional and policy evidence supports the proposed programme enhancement:

10.1 Khalifa University Standing

Khalifa University of Science and Technology holds the following rankings as of 2026: QS World University Rankings 2026 — 177th globally; Times Higher Education Asia University Rankings 2025 — 37th in Asia; UAE's top university for eight consecutive years. This institutional standing provides the credibility context for an ADEK authorization application asserting a first-of-its-kind dual-credential programme pathway. KU's College of Medicine and Health Sciences (CMHS) already holds UGCC-approved BSCND 200–400 level syllabi, establishing the governance infrastructure into which the SPMD tracks will be integrated.

10.2 Gap Analysis Evidence

The formal gap analysis conducted by the BSCND pipeline team (documented in `Integration_Deliverables/_analysis.json`, version 1.0, dated May 14, 2026) systematically assessed 12 REPs UAE registration requirements against the current BSCND + Sports Medicine Minor curriculum. The bottom line finding: "The current BSCND program with the Sports Medicine Minor does NOT qualify graduates to obtain a UAE fitness-coach or personal-trainer licence." Only one of the 12 requirements — Sports Nutrition (addressed by NUTR 305 in the core BSCND curriculum) — was fully covered. The Concentration (SPMD 305–308) was designed to address all remaining 11 gaps.

10.3 Physical Manager Benchmark

The Physical Manager Program Plan (Cseh, K., 2018) provided an international benchmark for a degree-level physical and health science professional programme. The benchmark's Level 1 BSc content (training theory, weight and equipment training, CPR/First Aid) is addressed by SPMD 305 and SPMD 308. Level 2 Intermediate content (teaching theory, psychology, pedagogy, group and individual teaching) is addressed by SPMD 306 and SPMD 307. Level 3 MSc content (internal medicine, neurology, physiotherapy, manual therapies) is explicitly out of scope for the BSCND undergraduate programme and would require a separate postgraduate degree. Sport-specific practicals (gymnastics,

swimming, athletics, ball sports) are intentionally excluded as they fall outside the BSCND scope as a clinical nutrition and dietetics programme.

Document prepared: May 2026 | **Pipeline:** SPMD Roadmap Wave 3, Agent A6 | **Contact:** Dr. Carlo Raj, Program Director, BSCND — Khalifa University CMHS

Inferred content flag: SPMD 305–308 CLOs and ICREPs alignments are inferred from Habiba correspondence and published competency frameworks. Faculty validation required before any formal committee submission.